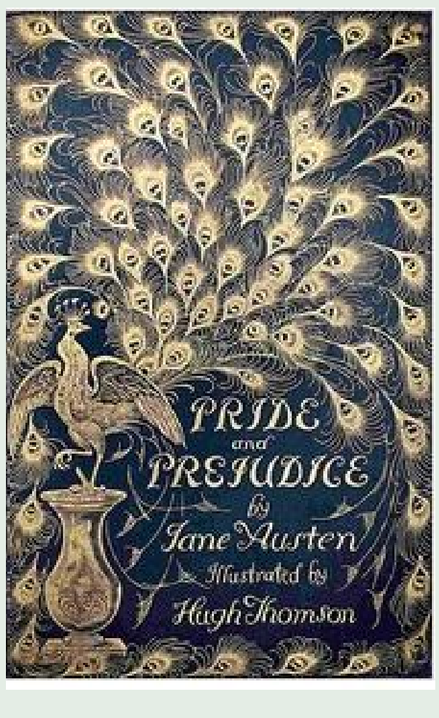
PROJECT GUTENBERG

An open library. A clearer path to the first page.

A responsive website redesign for finding the right book, starting with the story, and reading offline with confidence.

Design study · 2 November 2026
Independent student concept · Not an official redesign



Jane Austen · Pride and Prejudice
Original Hugh Thomson artwork · eBook #1342

PROJECT OVERVIEW

Protect the mission. Remove the friction.

Project Gutenberg offers free public-domain literature, sustained by volunteers. This concept keeps the collection's historic identity while making edition selection, low-data downloads and mobile reading easier to understand.

4 core screens

Home, Search, Book Detail and Reader; desktop and mobile, plus Home and Detail on tablet.

10 observed findings

Expert review informed by live Chromium screenshots and DOM measurements on 2 November 2026.

3 reader tasks

Find eBook #1342, navigate chapters, and choose a small compatible offline file.

PROVISIONAL PERSONAS — HYPOTHESES, NOT INTERVIEWED USERS

Two people to design for

Maya / Literature student

Reads on a phone between classes. Needs a specific English text, visible edition identity and a direct way into Chapter I.

T1 · Find Pride and Prejudice #1342
T2 · Chapter I → Chapter II → details

Daniel / Leisure reader

Uses an e-reader and a limited connection. Needs the smallest suitable file and plain-language transfer guidance.

T3 · Choose a small compatible file and find transfer instructions

PROPOSED ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA — NOT MEASURED OUTCOMES

What success would look like

Discovery	Identify #1342 from the three displayed records using language, illustration credit and ID; reach Reader in 3 activations from Home via query submission.
Reading	Use Chapter II, Contents and Book details without relying on browser Back; desktop prose measure targets 60–75 characters.
Offline choice	See 23.7 MB illustrated and 595 kB text-only EPUB together; locate device guidance without opening a hidden format group.
Responsive access	At 390 px, all content reflows within the frame; imagery stays within available width; mobile controls are at least 44 × 44 px.

An evidence-led concept, not a validation claim

Research is an expert heuristic review, not a user study. No keyboard or screen-reader audit, original contrast measurement, device-delivery test or usability test was completed. This submission cannot guarantee an evaluation outcome.

Source: gutenberg.org and eBook #1342 · Research date: 2 November 2026 · Screens are static, not wired. Existing artwork, credits and licensing remain accessible. No accounts, cloud sync or bookmarks are introduced.

Submission note · The Starter plan permits three pages. All eight numbered deliverable sections are retained across Research, Style Guide and Responsive Screens pages, rather than eight separate pages. The optional prototype is documented as a static flow map, not wired. Confirm view-access permissions before sharing.

Keep the library. Clarify the journey.

Ten observations across discovery, book choice and reading—prioritized by task impact, not by aesthetic preference.

EXPERT HEURISTIC REVIEW / 2 NOVEMBER 2026

Live Chromium screenshots and DOM measurements. Desktop: 1440 × 1000; mobile: 390 × 844. Eight Nielsen heuristics are represented (H1–H8); this is not a complete ten-heuristic audit or a user study.

Severity ≠ measured user impact

0 None · 1 Cosmetic · 2 Minor · 3 Major · 4 Catastrophic

No severity 4 problem was demonstrated. Findings are bounded to the inspected views and date.

Findings & resolution register

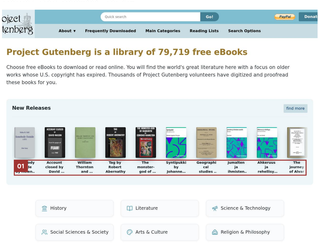
ID	Observation / evidence	Heuristic / severity	Design response	Verification
F01	**New Releases merges or truncates author and title.** From: "William Thornton and ..."	H8 · Aesthetic / minimalist **Severity 2**	Separate wrapping title and author.	Verify every card at 1440, 768 and 390 px.
F02	**Same title and author conceal record differences.** Search shows #1342, #42671, #26301, #20687, #20686.	H6 · Recognition over recall **Severity 3**	Use verified language, illustrator and eBook ID.	Identify #1342 without guessing from covers.
F03	**Download count lacks a visible time period.** Search: "212453 downloads"; detail says last 30 days.	H1 · Visibility of status **Severity 1**	Omit volatile counts; label "downloads in last 30 days" if used.	Check every count has a period and date context.
F04	**Summary provenance is hidden before expansion.** "Automatically generated" tail is display:none until Read more.	H5 · Error prevention **Severity 2**	Keep generated-summary disclosure beside the summary.	Disclosure visible before any activation.
F05	**Low-data EPUB is hidden under other formats.** 23.7 MB recommended; 595 kB without images in expanded rows.	H2 · Match with real world **Severity 2**	Show illustrated and text-only EPUB side by side.	Find smaller file and transfer help from Detail.
F06	**Reader entry starts at front matter and loses masthead.** Entry metadata occupies x89 y10 w1270 h414 in research capture.	H4 · Consistency / standards **Severity 2**	Lightweight library shell and direct Chapter I entry.	Open prose while retaining original credits access.
F07	**Chapter view has no in-view contents or chapter tools.** Browser Back and top metadata remain available.	H3 · User control / freedom **Severity 2**	Show Contents, Chapter II and Book details.	Complete T2 without relying on browser Back.
F08	**Reader prose spans a very wide box.** 1296 px box on a 1440 px viewport.	H8 · Aesthetic / minimalist **Severity 2**	Constrain desktop text to a 680 px reading column.	Check rendered line measure at default font size.
F09	**Contents links are closely packed and small.** Adjacent Roman links 19 px high; ≈24.7 × 19 px.	H5 · Error prevention **Severity 2**	Spaced chapter rows with 48 px targets.	Inspect spacing; not a proven WCAG violation.
F10	**Mobile dedication image overflows the viewport.** 390 px viewport / 566 px document; image width 450 px.	H7 · Flexibility / efficiency **Severity 3**	Responsive image bounds and reflow.	At 390 px verify no horizontal document overflow.

EVIDENCE ATLAS / NUMBERED MARKERS CORRESPOND TO FINDING IDS

Eight supplied screenshots, with provenance intact

Every supplied screenshot is reproduced as a design-owned image with callouts at the observed issue regions. Reader entry, chapter view, collapsed and expanded summary, formats and mobile image evidence remain distinct. Measurements refer to the original research viewports; panels are scaled for comparison. Original reference nodes are untouched.

Home / New Releases · ref 9:2



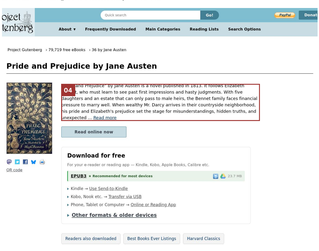
F01 · Author and title merge in a narrow shelf. Split the fields and allow wrapping; do not infer the hidden text.

Search / Record ambiguity · ref 5:2



F02 + F03 · Matching labels obscure record identity; the count has no time period. Research count is a dated observation, not a live metric.

Detail / Collapsed summary · ref 7:2



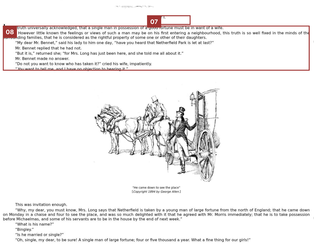
F04 · Disclosure is absent from the collapsed excerpt. This finding concerns provenance visibility, not summary accuracy.

Reader / Front-matter entry · ref 6:2



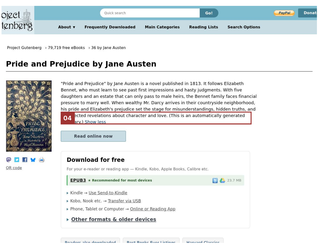
F06 + F09 · Entry begins with metadata and front matter rather than prose. Roman-number contents links are adjacent and 19 px high in the original capture. Keep the source accessible, but give Chapter I a direct entry.

Reader / Chapter I · ref 8:2



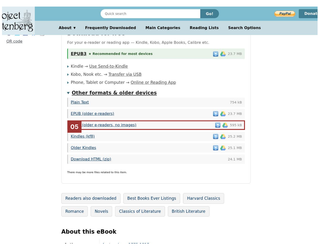
F07 + F08 · No in-view chapter or contents tools appear in this view; browser Back and top metadata still exist. Prose box measures 1296 px on a 1440 px viewport. Neither a dead end nor a measured comprehension failure is claimed.

Detail / Expanded summary · ref 10:2



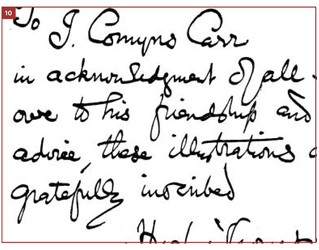
F04 · After Read more, the automatically generated summary disclosure appears at the excerpt's tail. DOM inspection confirmed it was display:none before expansion. Compare the collapsed state at ref 7:2.

Detail / Expanded formats · ref 12:2



F05 · The 595 kB no-images EPUB sits beneath "Other formats & older devices". These are displayed sizes, not measured download bytes.

Mobile / Dedication image · ref 11:2



F10 · Supplied crop shows the dedication clipping at its edge. Research measured 450 px image / 566 px document against 390 px viewport. Crop alone is not a complete reflow audit.

PRIORITIES / PROPOSED ORDER

Fix these five first

01 · F02	Recognize the right record Search + Detail / T1	Confirm the #1342 identity without cover-based assumptions.
02 · F10	Reflow mobile reading Reader / T2	Inspect 390 px width and responsive artwork; then test in a browser.
03 · F05	Expose the smaller file Detail / T3	Choose text-only EPUB and locate compatible transfer instructions.
04 · F07	Make reader wayfinding visible Reader / T2	Chapter I → Chapter II → details with in-view controls.
05 · F01	Make catalog cards legible Home / T1	Inspect title/author separation at all three widths.

Sources & limits of the evidence

https://www.gutenberg.org/
https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/search/?query=pride+and+prejudice
https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1342
https://www.gutenberg.org/cache/epub/1342/pg1342-images.html#Chapter_I

Observed 2 November 2026. Search already has aria-label "Search books"; no missing-label claim is made. No keyboard/screen-reader audit or original contrast measurement was performed. Wide prose is a layout finding, not a measured comprehension failure. Inline-link target exceptions mean F09 is not a proven WCAG violation. F10 is measured overflow, not a full reflow certification.

Evidence is bounded to the inspected screens, date and measured viewports. Counts may change. Displayed file sizes are not measured download bytes. Proposed resolutions and acceptance checks have not been user-tested; no device-delivery test was completed.

A library, not a bookstore.

Eleven supplied reference crops. The visual direction comes from the collection itself: old paper, enduring literature and authentic book art.

Literary

Bookish serif, fine rules, original illustration.

Welcoming

Warm paper, plain language, clear invitations.

Trustworthy

Visible provenance, precise metadata, honest choices.



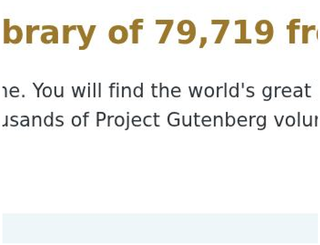
14:2 · Home / navigation

BORROW

Recognizable catalog labels and a clear library-navigation band.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Carry the historic masthead identity from Home into a calmer editorial wordmark and simpler navigation.



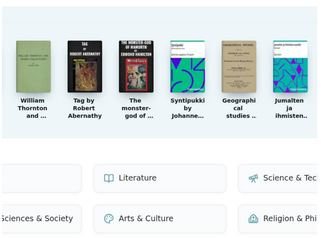
13:2 · Home / mission

BORROW

A direct statement of free access and generous white space.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Shorten the promise and make search the obvious next step.



15:2 · Home / cover shelf

BORROW

Real historic covers and a browsable library rhythm.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Never truncate author into title; separate the metadata.



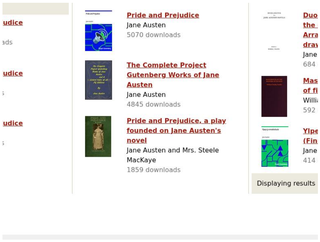
16:2 · Search / result hierarchy

BORROW

Differentiated title and author in the catalog result.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Make the query and sort explicit; identify records with verified metadata.



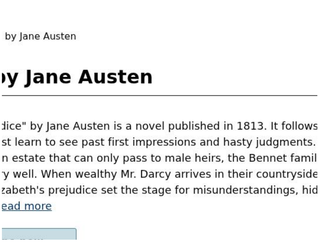
21:2 · Search / edition thumbnails

BORROW

A scannable collection of covers and catalog records.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Distinguish verified eBook IDs and known metadata, not invented edition facts.



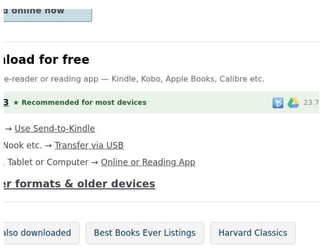
19:2 · Detail / book identity

BORROW

Literary title, author and book-focused hierarchy.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Pair the identity with the peacock cover from full Detail ref 7:2, and keep summary provenance visible.



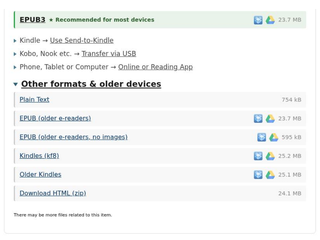
17:2 · Detail / recommendation

BORROW

Restrained green to guide a useful primary choice.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Do not hide the low-data alternative behind the recommendation.



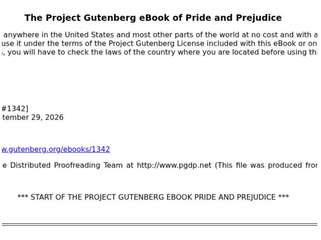
18:2 · Detail / expanded formats

BORROW

Format specificity, real file sizes and device guidance.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Put illustrated and text-only EPUB together with plain labels.



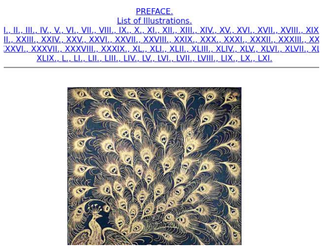
20:2 · Reader / front matter

BORROW

Archival credits and the Project Gutenberg License.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Keep accessible without requiring readers to pass through it before prose.



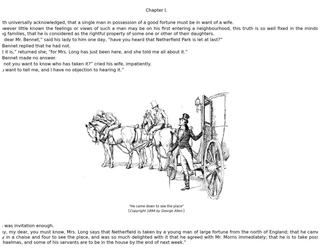
22:2 · Reader / Roman contents

BORROW

Historical chapter language and original peacock ornament.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Use spacious chapter rows; do not preserve cramped inline targets.



23:2 · Reader / prose & illustration

BORROW

Austen's original prose and Hugh Thomson's line art.

IMPROVE / QUALIFY

Narrow the reading measure and scale illustrations to the viewport.

Preserve the history. Improve the interface.

All eleven images are new design-owned layers from the supplied references; original nodes stay read-only. Source screens: gutenberg.org Home, Search, eBook #1342 and its HTML reader. Reference numbers identify the supplied crops; the complete Home and Detail captures supply the historic masthead and cover context.

Original Pride and Prejudice artwork is credited to Hugh Thomson. No stock photography, generated covers, commercial pricing or account features are introduced. Front matter, source credits and licensing remain part of the reading journey.